Pattern Headings: Literatures

H 1156

Pattern: *English literature*

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A. Recent revisions

2026-01: Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

B. Types of headings covered by the pattern

This instruction sheet contains the free-floating subdivisions that may be used under headings for individual literatures and genres of those literatures.

Examples of these literature headings:

Swedish literature
French drama
German essays
Epic poetry, Finnish
Short stories, Chinese

Appropriate subdivisions may also be used under headings formed using the free-floating subdivision ***--Literatures*** under names of regions and countries, for example, ***America--Literatures***.

Period subdivisions are listed first (section E), author groups second (section F), and topical and form subdivisions last (sections G and H), to suggest the proper order for considering these elements in the formulation of literature subject headings. Limitations on combining multiple subdivisions in a single string appear in the appropriate sections below.

C. Types of headings not covered by the pattern

The category does not include the general heading ***Literature***, general headings for genres without adjectival qualifiers, such as ***Drama*** or ***Poetry***, nor non-belletristic genres such as ***Scientific literature***.

D. Conflicts

D.1. General practice

Any subdivision listed here can be used as a free-floating subdivision under any heading belonging to the category if it is appropriate and no conflict exists in the subject authority file. Subject authority records may exist for headings employing variant phrases or subdivisions equivalent to subdivisions on this list.

D.2. LC practice

If an exceptional variant form is to be retained, make a UF reference from the equivalent free-floating subdivision form following the procedures in H 195 if the reference does not yet exist. Otherwise, submit a proposal to change the variant form along with all bibliographic records requiring correction following the procedures in H 193.

E. Period subdivisions

The listed period subdivisions evolved from English literature practice and should be used only when appropriate for other literatures. If they are inappropriate for specific literatures, special periods should be established where needed under individual literatures and genres.

E.1. Limitations for period subdivisions

Period subdivisions may be followed by topical and form subdivisions from sections G and H, with the noted exceptions, but may not be combined with author group subdivisions from sec. F, nor used after headings for literatures or literary genres with geographic subdivision.

Period subdivisions are used only after headings for individual literatures formulated as ***[. . .] literature*** and after major literary genres, that is, headings in the form ***[. . .] fiction***, ***[. . .] drama***, ***[. . .] poetry***, ***[. . .] essays***, or ***[. . .] prose literature***.

Period subdivisions may not free-float under headings modified by parenthetical qualifiers for language, for example, ***Nigerian fiction (English)***. However, period subdivisions may be individually established under headings for European literatures that are modified by parenthetical qualifiers for language.

Examples:

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Belgian literature (French)--20th century

Swiss poetry (German)--Early modern, 1500-1700
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E.2. Lists of period subdivisions

E.2.a. Period subdivisions under literatures and genres, except drama

$y Old English, ca. 450-1100
$y Middle English, 1100-1500
$y Early modern, 1500-1700
$y 18th century
$y 19th century
$y 20th century
$y 21st century

E.2.b. Period subdivisions under drama

$y To 1500
$y Early modern and Elizabethan, 1500-1600
$y 17th century
$y Restoration, 1660-1700
$y 18th century
$y 19th century
$y 20th century
$y 21st century

F. Author group subdivisions

F.1. General rule

Use the following free-floating subdivisions under any literature or major genre of a literature for author groups that identify subordinate bodies of that literature. Any subdivision that also designates the literature is not valid under that literature, for example, use ***English literature--Celtic authors***, but *not* "Celtic literature--Celtic authors". Author group subdivisions may be followed by any topical or form subdivision from sections G and H, but may not be combined in

a single heading with period subdivisions from sec. E nor used after headings for literary genres with geographic subdivisions.

Following this pattern, establish new subdivisions for internal *<<national>>*, *<<ethnic>>*, or *<<religious>>* groups *<<only>>*. For other author groups, follow the pattern of the phrase headings, ***Children's writings**, **English--[place]*** or ***Prisoners' writings, French--[place]***. However, for external author groups, that is, those living outside the country normally associated with the literature to which they are contributing, use simple geographic subdivision, for example, ***German literature--Romania***.

Subdivisions for religious author groups are used for literature written by authors who are members of the group, whether or not the literature includes religious themes. For example, assign ***American poetry--Christian authors*** to poetry by American Christians. Literature with religious themes is entered under a phrase heading for the literature, for example, ***Christian poetry, American***.

The literatures of the independent nations of Africa, Asia, and the Pacific must be established with the national or regional group as an independent literature (using a parenthetical language qualifier if necessary), for example, ***African literature (French)***. Since these are no longer considered subordinate groups within the general body of literature in a language, do not formulate headings such as ***French literature--African authors***.

F.2. List of author group subdivisions

$x Algerian authors

$x Anglican authors

$x Arab authors

$x Armenian authors

$x Asian authors

$x Azerbaijani authors

$x Bahraini authors

$x Bangladeshi authors

$x Bakhtiari authors

$x Basque authors

$x Bedouin authors

$x Bengali authors

$x Black authors [Not valid under headings for American literature or its genres.]

$x Buddhist authors

$x Calvinist authors

$x Caribbean authors

$x Catalan authors

$x Catholic authors

$x Celtic authors

$x Chinese authors

$x Christian authors

$x Christian Science authors

$x Czech authors

$x Czechoslovak authors

$x Dalit authors

$x Dravidian authors

$x Druze authors

$x East Asian authors

$x East Indian authors

$x European authors

$x Finnish authors

$x Foreign authors

$x Garifuna authors

$x German authors

$x Greek authors

$x Hindu authors

$x Hungarian authors

$x Icelandic authors

$x Iranian authors

$x Irish authors

$x Italian authors

$x Jaina authors

$x Japanese authors

$x Jewish authors

$x Jewish Christian authors

$x Korean authors

$x Kurdish authors

$x Kyrgyz authors

$x Latter Day Saint authors

$x Lebanese authors

$x Lutheran authors

$x Luxembourg authors

$x Madurese authors

$x Male authors

$x Māori authors

$x Maratha authors

$x Maya authors

$x Mennonite authors

$x Methodist authors

$x Minority authors

$x Mongolian authors

$x Muslim authors

$x Northern Irish authors

$x Orthodox Eastern authors

$x Palestinian Arab authors

$x Parsee authors

$x Polish authors

$x Protestant authors

$x Puritan authors

$x Pushto authors

$x Quaker authors

$x Romani authors

$x Romanian authors

$x Scottish authors

$x Sindhi authors

$x Slovak authors

$x South Asian authors

$x Swami-Narayani authors

$x Tibetan authors

$x Turkic authors

$x Turkish authors

$x Turkmen authors

$x Ukrainian authors

$x Welsh authors

$x White authors

$x Women authors

$x Yoruba authors

G. Topical subdivisions

G.1. General Rule

The following free-floating subdivisions may also be used under period subdivisions from section E or author group subdivisions from section F with the noted exceptions. They may also be used after headings for literary genres with geographic subdivisions.

G.2. List of topical subdivisions

A-D | E-H | I-M | N-S | T-Z

Topical subdivision	May Subd Geog	Notes
$x African influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.

Topical subdivision	May Subd Geog	Notes
$x American influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Appreciation	Yes	Use as a topical subdivision under individual literatures for works on public response and reception, praise, etc., of the literature.
$x Arab influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Asian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Audio adaptations		Use as a topical subdivision under individual literatures for works about audio adaptations of works from that literature. Not valid under period subdivisions.
$x Australian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Bibliography		Use as a topical subdivision under literatures for works about bibliography on those literatures.
$x Brazilian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Buddhist influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Caribbean influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Celtic influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Censorship	Yes	
$x Chinese influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Christian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Classical influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Comics adaptations		Not valid under period subdivisions.

Topical subdivision	May Subd Geog	Notes
$x Confucian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Criticism, Textual		
$x Czech influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Dutch influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Egyptian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x English influences		Not established under English literature. Use under other literatures as appropriate. Not valid under period subdivisions.
$x European influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Explication		
$x Film adaptations		Not valid under period subdivisions.
Film and video adaptations	--	*See "Film adaptations" and "Television adaptations"*
$x Finnish influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x First editions		Use as a topical subdivision under individual literatures for works about first editions of those literatures.
$z Foreign countries		Use as a geographic subdivision under individual literatures qualified by language or nationality. Not valid under subdivisions for periods, groups of authors, or places.
$z Foreign countries $x History and criticism		Use this subdivision combination as a topical subdivision under individual literatures. Not valid under subdivisions for periods, groups of authors, or places.
$x Foreign influences		Use as a topical subdivision under individual literatures further subdivided by place for works on general outside cultural influences on those literatures.

Topical subdivision	May Subd Geog	Notes
		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x French influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Galician influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x German influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Graphic novel adaptations		Not valid under period subdivisions.
$x Greek influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Haitian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Hebrew influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x History and criticism		Use as a topical subdivision under literary, music, film, television program, and video recording form headings.
$x History and criticism $x Theory, etc.		
$x Hungarian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Illustrations		Use as a topical subdivision under individual literatures, literary forms, and types of published materials for works about pictorial representation of those works.
$x Indian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Indic influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Iranian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Irish influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.

Topical subdivision	May Subd Geog	Notes
$x Islamic influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Italian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Jaina influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Japanese influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Korean influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Latin American influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Manuscripts		Use as a topical subdivision under individual literatures for works about manuscripts of those literatures.
$x Mayan influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Medieval influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Mediterranean influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Memorizing		
$x Mexican influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Minangkabau influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Musical settings		Use as a topical subdivision under individual literatures for works on musical compositions based on texts of those literatures.
$x Musical settings $x History and criticism		
$x Northern Thai influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.

Topical subdivision	May Subd Geog	Notes
$x Old Norse influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Periodization		
$x Persian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Polish influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Political aspects	Yes	Use as a topical subdivision under individual literatures for works on the political dimensions or implications of nonpolitical topics.
$x Portuguese influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Provençal influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Psychological aspects		
$x Publishing	Yes	
$x Roman influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Romanian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Russian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Sanskrit influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Scandinavian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Scottish influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Shamanistic influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.

Topical subdivision	May Subd Geog	Notes
$x Slavic influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Slovak influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Social aspects	Yes	
$x Sources		Use under types of literature for works about sources of ideas or inspiration for these literary works.
$x Soviet influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Spanish influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Stories, plots, etc.		Use as a topical subdivision under individual literatures for works about the stories or plots of those literatures.
$x Taoist influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Television adaptations		Not valid under period subdivisions.
$x Thai influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Themes, motives		Use as a topical subdivision under names of individual literary forms.
$x Translations		Use as a topical subdivision under names of individual literatures for works about translations of those literatures. Do not use for single translations.
$x Translations $x History and criticism		
$x Translations into French, [German, etc.]		Use as a topical subdivision under names of individual literatures for works about translations of those literatures into those languages.
$x Translations into French, [German, etc.] $x History and criticism		

Topical subdivision	May Subd Geog	Notes
$x Turkic influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Ukrainian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Urdu influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Uzbek influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x West Indian influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Western influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.
$x Yiddish influences		Not valid under period subdivisions or under headings for literatures identified in the subdivision.

H. Form subdivisions

H.1. General rule

The following free-floating subdivisions may also be used under period subdivisions from section E or author group subdivisions from section F with the noted exceptions. They may also be used after headings for literary genres with geographic subdivisions.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, Library of Congress catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT) to bring out the form(s) and/or genre(s) of the resource being cataloged. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Group Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged. The form subdivisions maintained on this list are not available for use by LC catalogers. Catalogers at institutions external to LC may use them as dictated by their own institutional policies.

H.2. List of form subdivisions

Form subdivision	May Subd Geog	Notes
$v Adaptations		Use as a form subdivision under individual literatures for collections of adaptations of those works.
$v Audio adaptations		Use as a form subdivision under individual literatures for collections of audio adaptations of works from that literature.
$v Bibliography		Use as a form subdivision under literatures for works consisting of bibliographies about the literature.
$v Bio-bibliography		Use as a form subdivision under literatures for works containing both biographical information about persons associated with the literature and bibliographies of writings by and/or about them.
$v Chronology		Use as a form subdivision under headings for literature for lists of dates of events pertinent to the subject in order of their occurrence.
$v Comics adaptations		Use as a form subdivision under individual literatures for collections of comics adaptations of those works.
$v Concordances		Use as a form subdivision under individual literatures and literary genres for indexes to the principal words found in those works.
$v Film adaptations		Use as a form subdivision under individual literatures for collections of film adaptations of those literatures.
Film and video adaptations	--	*See "Film adaptations" and "Television adaptations"*
$x First editions $v Bibliography		Use this subdivision combination as a form subdivision under individual literatures for lists of first editions of those literatures.
$v Graphic novel adaptations		Use as a form subdivision under individual literatures for collections of graphic novel adaptations of those literatures.

Form subdivision	May Subd Geog	Notes
$v Illustrations		Use as a form subdivision under individual literatures, literary forms, and types of published materials for collections of pictorial representations of those works.
$v Musical settings		Use as a form subdivision under individual literatures for musical scores or sound recordings in which those literary texts have been set to music.
$v Stories, plots, etc.		Use as a form subdivision under names of individual literatures for works consisting of summaries of the stories or plots of those literatures.
$v Television adaptations		Use as a form subdivision under individual literatures for collections of television adaptations of those literatures.
$v Translations		Use as a form subdivision under names of individual literatures for collections of translated works.
$v Translations into French, [German, etc.]		Use as a form subdivision under names of individual literatures for collections of translated works into those languages.

Revision history

2026-01: Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

2025-06: Revised template. Added missing text.

2024-08: Updated to new template. Added missing subdivisions.